CAMBRIDGE, UNITED KINGDOM

Fitzwilliam Museum: Masterpieces

Twenty works shaped by thresholds, enclosed spaces and the things left between figures.



The Annunciation takes place across an interval. Gabriel and Mary occupy separate sides of the courtyard, while the architecture leads attention beyond them. A Rossetti encounter has almost the opposite difficulty: two resembling couples occupy a wood too crowded to keep their identities comfortably apart. Both pictures make space part of the event rather than a neutral container for it.

Other works in this selection need far less narrative. A cup and saucer can occupy an entire painting; boats can establish a lagoon with only sparse accents. Following these changes of scale is one way to read the collection without asking every work to declare its historical importance.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/fitzwilliam-museum

The selection · 20

1. The Bridesmaid
   John Everett Millais · 1851
2. The Annunciation
   Domenico Veneziano · c. 1442–1448
3. The Miracle of Saint Zenobius
   Domenico Veneziano · 1442-1448
4. The Nativity
   Domenico Ghirlandaio · 1492
5. How They Met Themselves
   Dante Gabriel Rossetti · 1864
6. Joan of Arc
   Dante Gabriel Rossetti · 1882
7. Girl at a Lattice
   Dante Gabriel Rossetti · 1862
8. Golden Water
   Dante Gabriel Rossetti · 1858
9. Portrait of an Unknown Man
   Frans Hals · 1660-1663
10. The Lagoon towards Murano from the Fondamenta Nuove
    Francesco Guardi · 1765 - 1770
11. White Cup and Saucer
    Henri Fantin-Latour · 1864
12. Working the Land
    Paul Gauguin · 1873
13. Lindisfarne
    Thomas Girtin · 1798
14. Hydrangeas
    Philip Wilson Steer · 1901
15. The Three Marys at the Empty Sepulchre
    Giovanni Battista Gaulli · c.1684 - c. 1685
16. The Adoration of the Shepherds
    Luis Tristán · 1620
17. The Tombs of the Sultans near Cairo
    Elijah Walton · 1865
18. The Andrews Family
    James Wills · 1749
19. Maria Isabel de Borbón, Queen of the Two Sicilies
    Vicente López Portaña · 1829–1830
20. Unknown Man
    Charles Beale · 1693

01 / 20

The Bridesmaid

John Everett Millais

1851 · Fitzwilliam Museum



John Everett Millais. The Bridesmaid. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The mass of red hair makes a strong first boundary around the face, but the small action of the hands also calls for attention. Foreground objects and dark space behind keep the figure close. Millais lets an intimate gesture compete with a conspicuous surface, so that the portrait-like presence does not exhaust the scene.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Annunciation

Domenico Veneziano

c. 1442–1448 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Domenico Veneziano. The Annunciation, predella panel from the St. Lucy Altarpiece. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The passage between Gabriel and Mary makes their separation conspicuous. It also draws attention toward a closed door beyond. The museum notes that the panel was trimmed on the left, disturbing its original architectural symmetry. Its present balance should therefore be read as the surviving arrangement of an altered object, not an untouched geometrical ideal.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

The Miracle of Saint Zenobius

Domenico Veneziano

1442-1448 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Domenico Veneziano. The Miracle of St. Zenobius. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The street gives the bishop, child and surrounding figures defined positions from which to act and respond. Architecture helps separate their gestures without dispersing the episode. This panel and the *Annunciation* once belonged to the same altarpiece’s lower strip, or predella; their small scenes had a place beneath a much larger sacred image.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

The Nativity

Domenico Ghirlandaio

1492 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Domenico Ghirlandaio. The Nativity. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Overlapping heads and hands gather closely around the child. The shelter and animals keep the foreground compact, even though a landscape continues beyond it. Ghirlandaio makes attention itself the group’s shared action: the surrounding figures are linked by where they look and kneel rather than a sequence of dramatic movements.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

How They Met Themselves

Dante Gabriel Rossetti

1864 · Bodycolour on paper · Fitzwilliam Museum



Dante Gabriel Rossetti. How They Met Themselves. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/dante-gabriel-rossetti/how-they-met-themselves-1864 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The encounter depends on resemblance. A couple meets another pair like themselves, and the wood has little room to separate the doubled bodies. Crossed hands and swords intensify that crowding. The familiar becomes difficult precisely because it recurs where it should not: the painting’s disturbance is built from recognition rather than an unidentifiable monster.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Joan of Arc

Dante Gabriel Rossetti

1882 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Dante Gabriel Rossetti. Joan of Arc. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The sword rises near Joan’s face while her gaze turns upward. Metal and rich fabric give the close figure physical substance, but the gesture interrupts any straightforward action of combat. Armour establishes a martial role; the direction of attention complicates it, keeping devotion and military equipment within the same confined view.

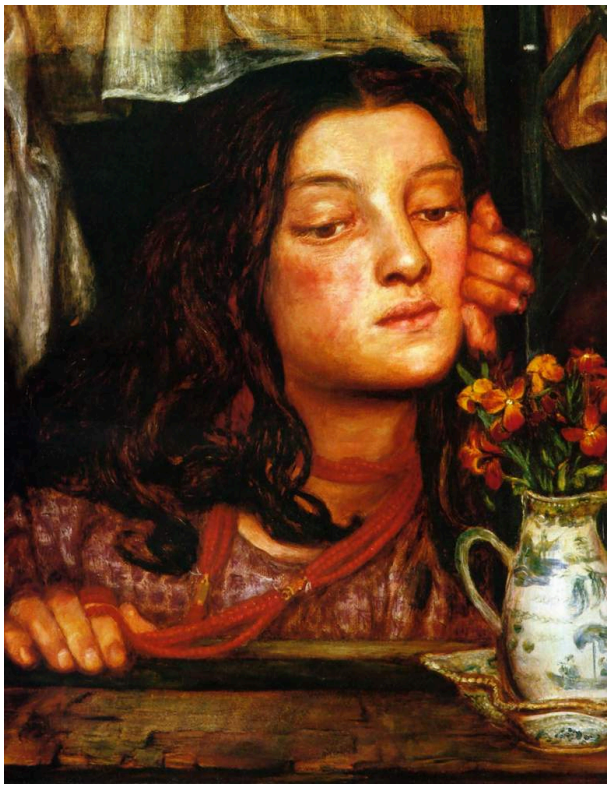
Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Girl at a Lattice

Dante Gabriel Rossetti

1862 · Oil on canvas · Fitzwilliam Museum



Dante Gabriel Rossetti. Girl at a Lattice. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/dante-gabriel-rossetti/girl-at-a-lattice-1862 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The window is a boundary without a disclosed destination. The woman leans close to its ledge, yet her turned face prevents a simple exchange of looks with the spectator. Flowers add a near, tangible presence. What lies beyond the threshold remains less definite than the position of the figure beside it.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Golden Water

Dante Gabriel Rossetti

1858 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Dante Gabriel Rossetti. Golden Water. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/dante-gabriel-rossetti/golden-water-1858 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The dark vessel has weight because the woman’s arms contain it against her body. Hair, pale clothing and plants extend the upright arrangement around that central relation. The title may promise a narrative, but the image is largely still; its clearest information is how a person holds an object.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Portrait of an Unknown Man

Frans Hals

1660-1663 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Frans Hals. Portrait of an Unknown Man. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The face addresses the spectator more directly than the loosely handled grey garment describes every fold. A broad black hat gives the head a firm setting. Hals lets differing degrees of finish coexist: the clothing remains a field of strokes while the likeness holds together as a particular presence.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

The Lagoon towards Murano from the Fondamenta Nuove

Francesco Guardi

1765 - 1770 · Oil on canvas · Fitzwilliam Museum



Francesco Guardi. The Lagoon Looking toward Murano from the Fondamenta Nuove. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/francesco-guardi/the-lagoon-looking-toward-murano-from-the-fondamenta-nuove-1770 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Architecture is reduced to low marks along the horizon, leaving water and grey sky much more room. Boats and slender masts keep that openness from becoming unlocated. Guardi makes a city recognisable without a monumental façade dominating the view: the lagoon and the intervals between its small accents carry Venice here.

Object source · Open artwork

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White Cup and Saucer

Henri Fantin-Latour

1864 · Oil on canvas · Fitzwilliam Museum



Henri Fantin-Latour. White Cup And Saucer. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henri-fantin-latour/white-cup-and-saucer-1864 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The cup does not need an elaborate setting. Its rim, handle and rounded body divide white into different conditions of light, with the saucer and spoon offering a few related shapes. Isolation gives those distinctions enough attention to sustain the painting; the everyday vessel is neither hidden in a feast nor required to symbolise one.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Working the Land

Paul Gauguin

1873 · Oil on canvas · Fitzwilliam Museum



Working the land. WikiArt; Paul Gauguin. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The workers and animals remain within broad stretches of cultivated ground. Trees, low buildings and sky connect their labour to a continuous place. For readers who associate Gauguin with later, flatter arrangements, this early landscape is a useful complication: an artist’s name does not guarantee one unchanging way of constructing a scene.

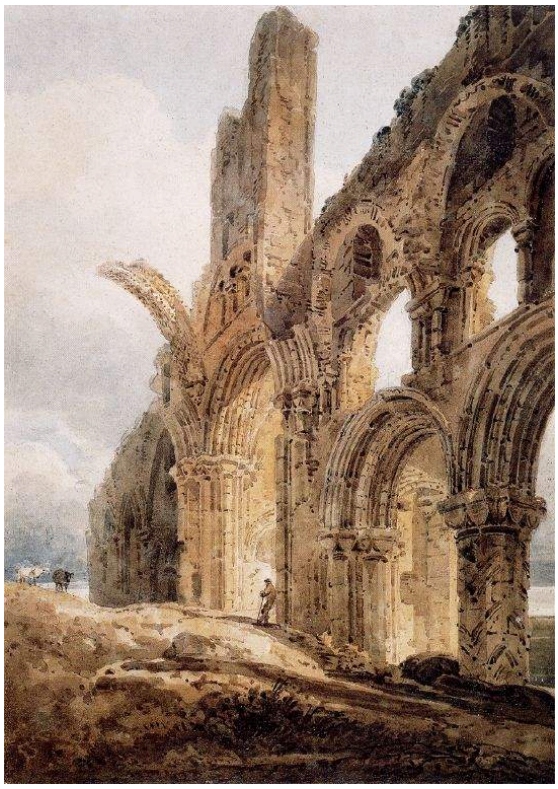
Object source · Open artwork

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Lindisfarne

Thomas Girtin

1798 · Watercolour · Fitzwilliam Museum



Thomas Girtin. Lindisfarne. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/thomas-girtin/lindisfarne-1798 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The sky enters the ruin through the missing masonry as well as above its surviving walls. Those openings are essential to the view’s structure. Girtin distinguishes stone from air without needing to reconstruct the building intact; the losses give the remaining arches their particular rhythm and exposure.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Hydrangeas

Philip Wilson Steer

1901 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Philip Wilson Steer. Hydrangeas. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Flowers, clothing and surroundings nearly share one busy pattern of light and marks. The reaching hand and face keep the woman’s activity readable within it. Steer allows that balance to remain close: enough distinction to follow a person reaching, enough continuity for the figure to belong to the same surface as the hydrangeas.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

The Three Marys at the Empty Sepulchre

Giovanni Battista Gaulli

c.1684 - c. 1685 · Oil on canvas · Fitzwilliam Museum



Giovanni Battista Gaulli. The Three Marys at the Empty Sepulchre. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/giovanni-battista-gaulli/the-three-maries-at-the-empty-sepulchre · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Hands direct attention toward an absence. Women approach while angels indicate the tomb, requiring the vacant place to carry the scene’s discovery. Colour helps keep the figures distinct, but gesture makes their relations intelligible. The event depends less on what occupies the centre than on how the group responds to what is missing.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

The Adoration of the Shepherds

Luis Tristán

1620 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Luis Tristán. The Adoration of the Shepherds. Image credit: Luis Tristán; Art UK. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Luis_Trist%C3%A1n_de_Escamilla_(1585-1624)_-_The_Adoration_of_the_Shepherds_-_M.78_-_Fitzwilliam_Museum.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The child anchors a dense gathering that continues upward into angels and darkness. Faces and bright cloth keep returning attention to particular bodies within the crowd. Light has an organising task: without its uneven distribution, the many figures could compete equally and weaken the concentration around the newborn.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: M.78

17 / 20

The Tombs of the Sultans near Cairo

Elijah Walton

1865 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Elijah Walton. The Tombs of the Sultans near Cairo. Image credit: Elijah Walton; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The monuments occupy less space than the sunset above them. Darker tracks and rough foreground ground lead toward a view whose principal change is in the sky. Walton gives the architecture a time and atmosphere, rather than isolating each structure as an object that could be removed from its surroundings.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 456*

18 / 20

The Andrews Family

James Wills

1749 · Fitzwilliam Museum



James Wills. The Andrews Family. Image credit: James Wills; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Five people share a terrace, but their heights and turns vary. The family relation is carried by that common space and coordinated presentation rather than a row of equivalent poses. Trees and landscape supply a setting large enough to hold them together while keeping seated and standing figures distinct.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 657

19 / 20

Maria Isabel de Borbón, Queen of the Two Sicilies

Vicente López Portaña

1829–1830 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Vicente López Portaña. Maria Isabel du Boubón, Queen of the Two Sicilies. Image credit: Vicente López Portaña; Art UK. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Vicente_L%C3%B3pez_Porta%C3%B1a_(1772-1850)_-_Mar%C3%ADa_Isabel_de_Borb%C3%B3n,_Queen_of_the_Two_Sicilies_-_PD.254-2015_-_Fitzwilliam_Museum.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The elaborate sleeves and headwear, dark dress and red fabric establish a ceremonial setting around the queen. A supported hand helps maintain the controlled standing pose. The extensive display is organised around a face, keeping public rank and individual likeness in relation rather than allowing either to account for the portrait alone.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: PD.254-2015

20 / 20

Unknown Man

Charles Beale

1693 · Fitzwilliam Museum



Charles Beale. Unknown man (1693). Image credit: Charles Beale; Source credit: Art UK. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The sitter’s name is unknown, but the portrait is not consequently unspecific. The turn of the head, white neckcloth and warm brown robe establish a particular arrangement against darkness. Light gathers at face and chest, making a directed presence available even where the historical identification has been lost.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 643

Leave room for what is not shown

Compare the empty passage in the *Annunciation*, the vacant tomb in Gaulli and the indefinite view beyond Rossetti’s window. Their gaps do different work. These comparisons need not follow gallery order; check the Fitzwilliam’s current information if a particular painting or work on paper is central to a visit.

Further reading

The Elements of Drawing

John Ruskin · Read free · English

Ruskin’s exercises in noticing edges, tones and natural forms accompany both the detailed nineteenth-century pictures and the more economical watercolours. They encourage returning to a particular visible feature before making a broad judgment.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12